2.1 Pilgrims and Puritans

"Are we there yet?" You've probably asked this question during a long car ride. Imagine sailing across an ocean in a cramped wooden ship. Colonists who braved the long voyage from England to North America may have thought they'd never arrive.

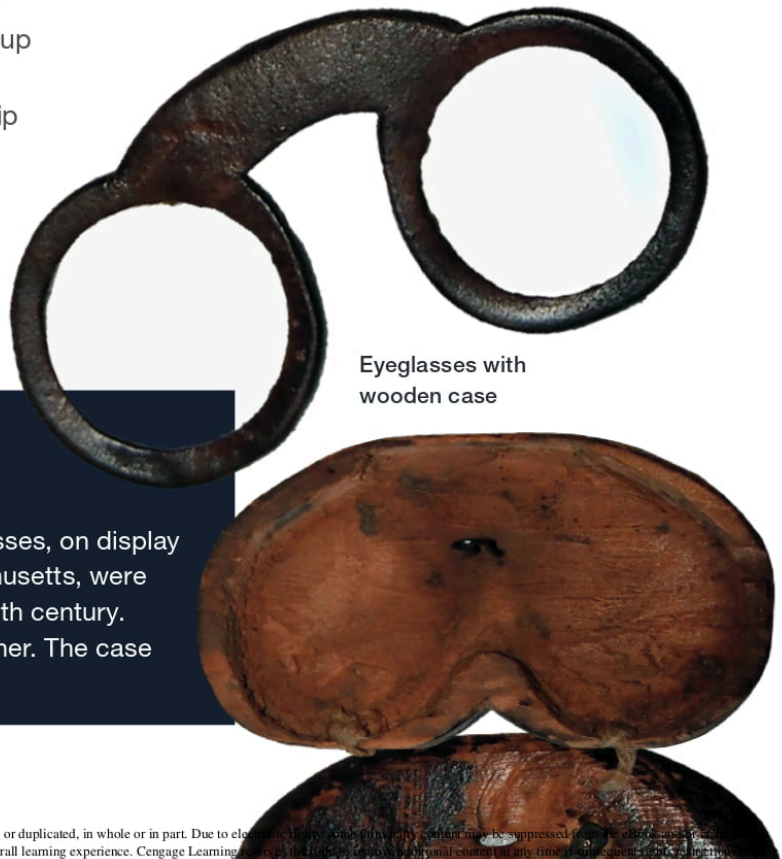
MAIN IDEA The New England colonies became a new home for groups who wished to create societies centered on their religious principles.

THE PILGRIMS FIND A HOME

During the early 1600s, European settlers continued to arrive in the American colonies, despite ongoing conflicts between Native Americans and colonists. At this time in England, religious **dissenters**, or people who disagreed with the beliefs of the Church of England, could be imprisoned or fined. Dissenters yearned for religious freedom so intensely that they left their homes, sailed across the ocean, and settled in the colonies. They became **separatists**, or people who created their own congregations outside of the Church of England.

The **Pilgrims** were one such group. They did not believe in the reforms instituted by the Church of England and saw complete separation as their only spiritual option. In September 1620, a group of Pilgrims boarded the *Mayflower* in England, bound for the northern part of Virginia. The ship strayed off course and landed on Cape Cod. Once they realized they would not land in Virginia, the Pilgrims established and signed the **Mayflower Compact**. This agreement laid out a plan for governing a new colony.

From Cape Cod, the Pilgrims moved to the area around what is now Plymouth, Massachusetts. During their first winter, half of the Pilgrims died from illness or exposure to the cold. The following spring, Native Americans who lived nearby, including Squanto, a member of the Pawtuxet, helped the Pilgrims grow their own food. They identified which crops grew best and when to plant them. They also showed the Pilgrims how to use herring, a local fish, to fertilize the crops. As experienced local planters, Native Americans also shared their knowledge of how to plant corn, beans, and squash together for the best results. The two groups celebrated the Pilgrims' first harvest in a three-day celebration considered the first Thanksgiving.



Eyeglasses with wooden case

Pilgrim Hall Museum Plymouth, Massachusetts

Even Pilgrims wore spectacles. These eyeglasses, on display at Pilgrim Hall Museum in Plymouth, Massachusetts, were probably made in England sometime in the 17th century. They are made of glass, horn, wood, and leather. The case is carved from pinewood.

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A CITY UPON A HILL

Like the Pilgrims, the **Puritans** believed that the Church of England needed additional reform. Unlike the Pilgrims, however, the Puritans wanted to reform the church from within.

Beginning in 1630, the Puritans began their migration from England to Massachusetts Bay. They arrived as part of the Massachusetts Bay Company, believing God wanted them to create a moral community. As Puritan leader John Winthrop said, the colony would be "as a City upon a Hill, the Eyes of all people are upon us."

The Puritans' system of self-governance was called the New England Way. The church was the center of the community, and all citizens were required to attend. Puritans believed that a congregation, bound by a sacred oath, held all authority and could punish members who disagreed with church doctrine. People who tried to leave a congregation could lose their property. The Puritans were dissenters who did not allow dissent within their own communities.

Not all Puritans agreed with the New England Way. In 1636, clergyman Thomas Hooker and a group of Puritans left Massachusetts to found a new colony in Connecticut. Three years later, in a sermon, Hooker provided inspiration for the **Fundamental Orders of Connecticut**. This document established a General Assembly of representatives from many towns. Unlike in Massachusetts, church membership was not a condition for voting.

In 1631, religious dissenter and Pilgrim minister **Roger Williams** arrived in Massachusetts Bay Colony. He attacked laws requiring church attendance and tax support of Puritan churches and was **banished**, or sent away from the colony. In 1636, he bought land from the Narragansett and founded the colony of Rhode Island. He based this new colony on the idea that church and state affairs should be kept separate.

In 1637, Massachusetts Bay Colony leaders banished another dissenter. **Anne Hutchinson** had angered orthodox Puritans by teaching that people had to respond directly to God, not the church, for their actions. Hutchinson also believed that ministers were unnecessary. She founded a settlement in the colony of Rhode Island.



Built in England in 1956, the *Mayflower II* is a full-scale replica of the vessel that brought the Pilgrims from England to North America in 1620. Upon completion, it sailed from England to New England following the Pilgrims' route. It remains a working sailing ship, moored at Plymouth, Massachusetts.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the Mayflower Compact and why was it important?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why did the Puritans link citizenship to church membership?
3. **MAKE GENERALIZATIONS** Why did some groups leave the Massachusetts Bay Colony to establish new colonies?

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